SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #111 · GRACE & WORKS

“I must keep the rules to stay in God’s favor.”

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Where it often comes from

A legalistic church background with long lists of do’s and don’ts. A home where approval depended on obedience. Fear of God’s anger when you slip. Measuring spirituality by outward behavior. Never fully understanding grace.

What Scripture teaches

God’s commands are good, and obedience matters. But we do not earn or keep God’s favor by rule-keeping. Through faith in Christ we have peace with God and stand in grace. If righteousness came through the law, Christ died for nothing. Grace that depends on works would no longer be grace. We obey because we stand in God’s favor, not to stay there.

> *“Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have gained access by faith into this grace in which we stand. And we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God”* **(Romans 5:1–2)**.

Also see

> “I do not set aside the grace of God. For if righteousness comes through the law, Christ died for nothing” **(Galatians 2:21)**.

> “And if it is by grace, then it is no longer by works. Otherwise, grace would no longer be grace” **(Romans 11:6)**.

> “I would like to learn just one thing from you: Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law, or by hearing with faith? Are you so foolish? After starting in the Spirit, are you now finishing in the flesh?” **(Galatians 3:2–3)**.

> “For sin shall not be your master, because you are not under law, but under grace” **(Romans 6:14)**.

Common self-statements

- One slip and I lose God’s favor.
- God only likes me when I follow the rules.
- I have to keep earning God’s approval.
- My standing with God depends on my behavior.
- If I break a rule, God turns away.
- I need more rules to stay safe.

Common logical errors

- **Performance-based thinking:** Believing God’s favor depends on your record.
- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Believing you are either in favor or out with each action.
- **Fear-based obedience:** Obeying out of fear of losing God rather than love.
- **Discounting grace:** Treating Christ’s work as not enough.

Challenging questions

- How do I have peace with God, according to Romans 5:1?

- In what do I stand?
- What would Christ's death mean if righteousness came by rules?
- Can grace depend on works and still be grace?
- Am I obeying out of love or fear?
- What rules have I added that God never gave?
- What would obedience look like if I knew I was secure?

Truth summary

> I do not have to keep the rules to stay in God's favor. Through faith in Christ, I have peace with God and stand in His grace. My standing depends on Jesus, not my performance. I obey God because I am loved and secure, not to earn or keep His favor.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Obedience
- Commandments
- Salvation
- Love, By God

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> **Overcoming Anxiety** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must keep the rules to stay in God's favor"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must keep the rules to stay in God's favor." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How do I have peace with God?
- ☐ In what do I stand?
- ☐ What would Christ's death mean if rules saved?
- ☐ Can grace depend on works?
- ☐ Am I obeying from love or fear?
- ☐ What rules have I added that God didn't give?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I stand in God's grace through Christ.
- ☐ I have peace with God through faith.
- ☐ My standing depends on Jesus, not my record.
- ☐ I obey because I am loved, not to stay loved.
- ☐ Sin is not my master; I am under grace.
- ☐ Grace is a gift, not a wage.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Romans 5:1–2**
  "Therefore, since we have been justified through faith, we have peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom we have gained access by faith into this grace in which we stand. And we rejoice in the hope of the glory of God."
- [ ] **Galatians 2:21**
  "I do not set aside the grace of God. For if righteousness comes through the law, Christ died for nothing."
- [ ] **Romans 11:6**
  "And if it is by grace, then it is no longer by works. Otherwise, grace would no longer be grace."
- [ ] **Galatians 3:2–3**
  "I would like to learn just one thing from you: Did you receive the Spirit by works of the law, or by hearing with faith? Are you so foolish? After starting in the Spirit, are you now finishing in the flesh?"
- [ ] **Romans 6:14**
  "For sin shall not be your master, because you are not under law, but under grace."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Standing in grace log:** Each day, write one way I obeyed God out of love and one reminder that I stand in grace.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Romans 5:1–2 becomes: "Therefore, since **Sarah** has been justified through faith, **she** has peace with God through our Lord Jesus Christ, through whom **she** has gained access by faith into this grace in which **she** stands."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write down the rules you feel you must keep,** and mark which ones come from Scripture and which from people.
- ☐ **Read Galatians 3:1–14,** and write what Paul says about rules and the Spirit.
- ☐ **After a failure, say aloud:** "I still stand in grace," then take one good next step.
- ☐ **Do one act of obedience this week** simply out of love for God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must keep the rules to stay in God's favor": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One act of obedience from love
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must keep the rules to stay in God's favor.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that I stand in Your grace through Jesus. Help me reject the lie that I must keep the rules to stay in Your favor. Free me from fear-based obedience, and let my obedience flow from love and gratitude. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.